

Easter Offensive: Quang Tri

US and ARVN commanders had been anticipating a major North Vietnamese offensive in the early months of 1972, but when the action began, the South Vietnamese forces were in disarray and US support was limited because of ongoing Vietnamization.

◀◀ BEFORE

Bordering the DMZ, Quang Tri province had been a key target for communist attacks since the start of the war.

HISTORY OF BATTLES

In 1967, US forces tried to secure the border area with a **chain of firebases** along the DMZ. These came under attack in the **run-up to the Tet Offensive**, as did Quang Tri City, the capital of the province. The **siege of the combat base at Khe Sanh** was one of the fiercest engagements in the war.

CHANGING THE GUARD

In October 1971, the ARVN's newly formed **Third Division**, under General Vu Van Giai, replaced the departing US 101st Airborne Division, which had previously defended Quang Tri province.

By March 1972, the American policy of Vietnamization had reduced the American presence to a fraction of its former might. Yet the ARVN still depended heavily on American support to operate effectively against the NVA and Viet Cong. US Army advisers were working with the ARVN Third Division, in charge of defending the Quang Tri region of Military Region 1, the northernmost zone bordering the DMZ, but the ARVN forces were thinly stretched.

Late in March, the ARVN Joint General Staff (JGS) learned the North Vietnamese attack would begin on March 29 and ordered an alert. However, ARVN forces were unprepared. General Giai, commanding the Third Division, was in the process of switching his Second Infantry with the 56th Infantry, which meant that neither regiment was in protective strongpoints when the attack commenced. Moreover, both Military Region 1 commander, General Hoang Xuan Lam, and General Giai expected the attack to come from the west, descending from the hills to the coastal plain, rather than across the DMZ, and the most effective regiment, the Second Infantry, was being removed from this sector.

South Vietnamese Marines holding some of the firebases behind the DMZ line had experienced NVA probes and seen activity over the previous days. Some artillery and air strikes had countered these attacks, but Giai felt he had no strength for a ground operation beyond his defense line.

The North Vietnamese had more than 30,000 troops backed by many guns and a full armored regiment. Their prongs of attack across the DMZ, which included tanks, took the ARVN by surprise.